



Discussion Guide: Brian McLaren

“Faith After Fundamentalism”

Reflect

- Brian begins his talk by suggesting that we all are born into something. Describe what sort of faith community you were born into. What did you value about that faith community? To what extent are your beliefs and values still aligned with the particular faith community you were born into?
- Brian describes four stages of faith development: **simplicity** (dualistic and concrete), **complexity** (pragmatic and curious), **perplexity** (unresolved questioning), and **harmony** (acceptance of past growth and expansion beyond it). In which stage would you place yourself right now?
- Describe when and how you transitioned into this stage of faith development. What brought about the transition and what changed about your faith as a result? Was the transition painful, liberating, or both?

Respond

- Brian compares faith development to a tree that acquires new rings each year. Even as a new ring is added, the previous rings remain. The rings expand and include continually. How might this metaphor help people who have different faith perspectives have more productive conversations with one another?
- Brian’s metaphor of a tree’s growth doesn’t just apply to an individual’s faith development but also to the development of faith communities over time. Describe an example in which you have seen a church expand beyond its traditional forms and beliefs without completely throwing out all that has come before. What do you value about this expand-and-include approach?